believed that there was little the US could or should do directly about Kashmir.[25]

The second task (economic performance) became harder for India to achieve over the next year and a half when the monsoon failed again in 1966, causing further food shortages and a major famine. Throughout, however, Johnson kept up the pressure on India to reform. He also pressed other countries to contribute more to the effort to prop up India.[26]

Indeed, since Washington and Moscow shared an interest in containing China by strengthening India, the administration did not even mind the Soviet contribution to Indian economic development.[27] Bowles wanted to do more to keep the Soviet Union out of the subcontinent, but most in the Johnson administration acknowledged that the Soviets would play a role in India. This recognition was also evident in Washington's reaction to Moscow trying its hand at postwar peacemaking between India and Pakistan in Tashkent in January 1966. Moscow hoped to get them to resolve their differences and come together against China—an objective the US itself had tried and failed to achieve in the past. The US reaction, as Komer had put it, was "let the Soviets have a try if they want."[28] Intelligence analysts expected India, on its part, would continue to maintain relations with both the US and the Soviet Union.[29] White House officials believed that improving Soviet-Pakistan relations put a limit to India-Soviet relations. And the administration's overall attitude toward India-Soviet relations was to "keep … the Indians from unbalanced surrender to the Soviets," but "Soviet help in itself [was] not intolerable."[30]

The US: Too Important to Jettison

India had no intention of surrendering to the Soviet Union. The Soviet option was indeed important as a source of economic and military assistance, and as a balance against China.[31] Moscow had also not suspended aid to India during the 1965 war. Nevertheless, Indian officials had been concerned by Soviet behavior in the midst of the fighting. Even those sympathetic to Moscow had noted its initial "vague" reaction and then pressure on India to accept a ceasefire.[32] The war and its aftermath thus served as a reminder of the downside of dependence, as well the need to keep it diversified—that meant maintaining the American option.